

How Executive Institutions Shape Affective Polarization: Evidence from Israel, 1975-2001

Isaac D. Mehlhaff*

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Abstract

Presidential institutions are often thought to foster political conflict and democratic instability. I offer a new perspective on this debate. I argue direct election of the executive dampens affective polarization by encouraging intra-party division and blurring party brands, thus weakening partisan attachments in the mass public. I identify a negative causal effect of presidentialism on affective polarization by leveraging an institutional reform in Israel, which temporarily elected its head of government by popular vote in the 1990s. I further demonstrate possible mechanisms connecting the behavior of party elites to mass attitudes toward parties. Direct executive elections increased uncertainty around parties' ideological profiles, weakened party organizations, and neutralized the tone of political headlines in *The Jerusalem Post*. The same features of presidentialism that complicate democratic governance may also help keep affective polarization at bay.

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*Neubauer Family Assistant Professor, Department of Political Science, The University of Chicago; imehlhaff@uchicago.edu.

As concerns about political polarization have mounted over the past two decades, many scholars and practitioners have laid blame on the shoulders of political institutions (Klein 2020; Persily 2015). In the United States, authors have targeted the primary system (Foley 2024), electoral system (Drutman 2020), Electoral College (Kamarck and West 2024), and Senate (Bowler 2022), among others, for reforms that would supposedly turn down the temperature in the political arena. Many proposed solutions take inspiration from other countries; variations in electoral rules, legislative institutions, and party systems all mold the contours of elite contestation and thus the degree of polarization in the mass public (Bernaerts et al. 2023; Bol et al. 2019; Katz and Mair 2018).

The sense that institutions contribute to political malaise in the United States and elsewhere comports with a longstanding idea in comparative politics that “institutional arrangements have an autonomous impact in shaping politics” (Mainwaring and Shugart 1997, p. 2).¹ Enthusiastic debate surrounds presidential institutions, in particular. Linz (1990) famously argued direct elections and fixed term lengths stoke political tension and make presidential systems more likely to experience democratic breakdown (cf. Lijphart 2004; Stepan and Skach 1993). This argument would lend support to the notion that mass polarization in the United States and other presidential democracies is partially a product of their executive institutions. Other scholars countered that presidentialism offers opportunities for coalition-building and that its impacts are difficult to disentangle from other characteristics of the geographic regions in which it has been implemented (Cheibub et al. 2004; Curini and Hino 2012; Horowitz 1990). I side with the latter group of scholars: presidential institutions are more likely to alleviate affective polarization than to aggravate it.

My central argument is that separate origin and survival—two institutional features distinguishing presidential systems from parliamentary ones—decrease affective polarization by generating greater ambiguity about party identities, both in government and in the electorate. When the head of government is directly elected, parties tend to be less ideologically cohesive, less prone to inflammatory cross-party rhetoric, and more likely to develop intra-party division. From the perspec-

¹Among other foundational works of “new institutionalism,” see Evans et al. (1985), Hall and Taylor (1996), and North (1990).

tive of democratic stability, divided government and inter-branch conflict have long been framed as presidentialism's weaknesses; they can produce gridlock and weaken programmatic coherence (Linz 1990; Stepan and Skach 1993).

Yet from the perspective of affective polarization, the implications are more complex. Precisely because the separation of origin and survival fosters more varied ideological commitments and opportunities for coalition-building, it blurs the boundaries of partisan identity and dilutes the sense of unified partisan camps. Voters are therefore less able to discern clear party brands and less likely to hold strong party identities. Affective polarization requires, in part, that partisans feel strong, positive affect toward their party and that these feelings are collectively shared. Such conditions are less likely to attain under presidentialism.

I first use cross-national survey data to show that respondents in presidential systems perceive a greater degree of variation in parties' left-right positions. Accordingly, they also display narrower divides and greater variation in their party affect—markers of lower affective polarization. The remaining analyses aim to uncover the causal effects of presidentialism on affective polarization and related outcomes. To identify these effects, I exploit an institutional reform that led Israel to temporarily elect its head of government by popular vote during the 1990s. Using country-year panel estimates of affective polarization from 1975-2001 in conjunction with synthetic control methods (Mehlhaff 2025; Xu 2017), I show the institutional reform led polarization to be lower than it would have been had Israel retained its pure parliamentary system.

I then probe possible mechanisms driving this relationship. Expert-coded data on party characteristics reveals switching from parliamentarism to a directly elected executive produced greater uncertainty about where Israel's parties stood on key issues and led to weaker party organizations with less proclivity to attack opposition parties (Düpont et al. 2022). Finally, I perform sentiment analyses of over 300,000 headlines published in *The Jerusalem Post*. Interrupted time series models indicate the implementation of direct elections had a sustained, neutralizing effect on the tone of political rhetoric in the media. These results offer a new perspective on the behavioral consequences of institutional design: by blurring party brands and making it difficult for voters to

develop and sustain strong party identities, presidential institutions may actually dampen affective polarization instead of instigate it.

Executive Institutions and Party Affect

Presidential systems are primarily distinguished from parliamentary ones by the separate origin and survival of the executive (Lijphart 1984; Shugart and Carey 1992; Shugart and Mainwaring 1997).² Presidents are elected separately *from* the legislature and, aside from impeachment for misconduct, they are not formally accountable *to* the legislature. By contrast, the selection of executives in parliamentary systems is typically determined by the success of their party in legislative elections, and their tenure is at the discretion of the majority party or coalition.³

Scholars have long pinpointed these institutional features as sources of problems plaguing presidential democracies. Linz (1990) touches off a robust debate over whether presidentialism is inimical to stable democracy (Chaisty et al. 2014; Cheibub and Limongi 2002). He argues presidentialism's rigid structure and winner-take-all elections provoke elite conflict, complicate coalition-building, and lead to policy gridlock (see also Lijphart 2004; Stepan and Skach 1993).

Perhaps counterintuitively, however, I argue the very institutional features that could make democratic governance difficult are also likely to keep affective polarization at bay. My theory centers on two claims: First, separate origin and survival of the executive generate inter-branch and intra-party conflict. As a result, parties in government are organizationally weaker, less ideo-

²Other variations in executive institutions, such as electoral concurrence, can also affect party politics (e.g. Sartori 1994). I set aside these sources of variation to focus on the more straightforward effects of separate origin and survival.

³For theoretical concision and empirical simplicity, I reduce the panoply of semi-presidential designs to two “pure” types.

logically distinct, and less capable of projecting party unity.⁴ Second, the wider range of *signals* coming from parties in government are reflected in a wider range of *attitudes* about parties in the electorate. Under presidentialism, partisans in the mass public are less likely to harbor strong positive feelings toward their own party, their feelings are less likely to be shared by co-partisans, and the outcome is a polity less riven by affective polarization.

Intra-Party Conflict under Presidentialism

The structural separation of executive and legislative branches under presidentialism generates *inter-branch* conflict, which typically implies *intra-party* conflict (Elinson 2023; Samuels and Shugart 2010). This dynamic begins during elections. Because executive and legislative candidates often court different constituencies, parties must navigate conflicting electoral strategies (Samuels and Shugart 2010). Voters may prioritize national policy in executive elections but the ability to secure pork in legislative ones (Samuels and Shugart 2003). Even when national policy drives both decisions, the median voter in a presidential contest is likely to differ from the median voter in many legislative districts (e.g. Ahler and Broockman 2018). Legislative and presidential candidates cannot always campaign on the same platform or respond to the same constituent priorities.

This “electoral separation of purpose” (Samuels and Shugart 2010, p. 123) leads parties to deprioritize policy in favor of vote-seeking strategies (Samuels 2002; Strom 1990). The immense value of the executive office leads parties to outsource their branding and messaging to presidential campaigns, producing atrophied party organizations and broader, less coherent programmatic appeals (Doyle and Power 2020; Mainwaring and Scully 1995). To command support beyond party loyalists, presidential candidates engage in personalistic campaigning and preemptive coalition-building (Curini and Hino 2012; Reiljan et al. 2024), further diluting the meaning of party labels

⁴I use “parties in government” as a reference to Key’s (1952) distinction between the three faces of parties: as organizations, in government, and in the electorate. The theoretical mechanics I discuss apply just as much to opposition parties as to ruling parties.

(Carey and Shugart 1995; Samuels and Shugart 2010). Riding presidential coattails to legislative control does not occur in parliamentary systems, where elections are fused and parties control campaigns, platforms, and messaging.

Separate origin continues to weaken party cohesion once parties enter government. Legislators answer to different constituencies and cultivate their own reputations (Carey and Shugart 1995), especially when presidents are unpopular or nearing the end of their terms (Carey 2009; Skowronek 1997). Presidents are also more likely than prime ministers to be political outsiders with limited party experience, making them less beholden to the party, less apt to uphold its image, and more willing to spurn legislative colleagues when strategically prudent (Samuels and Shugart 2010). Relative to parliamentary systems, presidencies therefore exhibit weaker party discipline and less executive control over legislative co-partisans (Carey 2009; Shugart and Mainwaring 1997).

Separate survival compounds these effects. Because voters can split their tickets, presidencies are more likely to experience divided government, with different parties controlling executive and legislative branches. These strange bedfellows are typically stuck with each other for fixed terms; legislatures cannot dismiss presidents when government is ineffective. Such conditions could lead presidents to pursue governing priorities through extra-constitutional actions (Linz 1990; Stepan and Skach 1993), but they also open the door to compromise and coalition-building.

Presidents facing divided government can broker among diverse legislative blocs, seeking compromise to avoid gridlock (Haggard and McCubbins 2001; Shugart and Carey 1992). They may even break with their own party when necessary (Corrales 2002). The outcome is a governing style that prioritizes centripetal policy appeals over cross-party confrontation (Curini and Hino 2012).⁵ Coalitional politics reinforce this pattern. Presidents lacking majority support must negotiate coalitions, sometimes stable and formed prior to the election (Cheibub et al. 2004; Horowitz 1990), other times assembled issue by issue (Chaisty et al. 2014; Shugart and Mainwaring 1997).

⁵Critically, only the executive is incentivized to move policies toward the center. Legislators, who answer to different constituencies, are not always incentivized similarly. The result is intra-party division on policy.

Such broad but shallow partnerships blur party brands by weakening ideological commitments (Samuels and Shugart 2010).

Varied Party Signals, Varied Party Affect

Separate origin and survival foster parties in government that are more internally discordant, less ideologically coherent, and less disciplined than under parliamentarism. These elite-level characteristics shape how citizens perceive and evaluate parties. Because citizens often rely on party elites for cues about where to stand on salient issues and how to interpret the political environment (Zaller 1992), programmatic disagreements—and, perhaps more importantly, the messaging associated with them (Iyengar et al. 2012)—are valuable sources of party affect (Gidron et al. 2025; Rogowski and Sutherland 2016). They reveal which social groups parties purport to represent and whether citizens can see their own priorities reflected in those of the party. For affective polarization to take hold, citizens must be able to easily ascertain their relationship to a party.

When party messages are clear, partisans respond with stronger party identification (Hetherington 2001). Parties operating under conditions of separate origin and survival, however, are likely to have weaker *party brands* than their counterparts in parliamentary systems. When parties send unclear or inconsistent signals, or when their positions converge on key issues, their brands become less distinguishable and voters find it harder to develop strong attachments (Dassonneville et al. 2023; Lupu 2016). If presidents cooperate with other parties in the legislature, coalitional politics further blur the line between one party and the next.⁶

To the extent that partisanship is a social identity (Green et al. 2002; Iyengar et al. 2012), this blurring partially dissolves symbolic boundaries between partisan in-groups and out-groups, making it harder for elites to activate strong in-party affect or sustain a cohesive partisan identity in the mass public. Compounding these effects, the personalist voting and weak party discipline characteristic of presidential systems lead voters to detach from parties at a higher rate (Dalton

⁶The blurring effect also occurs in parliamentary systems (e.g. Fortunato 2021). My claim is that inter-branch conflicts make this effect more common, and more severe, under presidentialism.

et al. 2000; Huber et al. 2005). This pattern is visible even in the United States—the contemporary archetype of affective polarization in a presidential democracy—where partisans display meaningful heterogeneity in how positively they evaluate their own party (Groenendyk et al. 2020; Young and de-Wit 2025).

Such intra-party heterogeneity carries ramifications for affective polarization, which implies not only that citizens feel warmly toward their in-party and coldly toward out-parties, but also that co-partisans *agree with each other* on those evaluations (Mehlhaff 2024). If some partisans feel strong positive affect toward their party but others do not, affective polarization will be lower than if all partisans concurred in that strong positive assessment. In short, intra-party conflict among elites engenders diffuse party perceptions among citizens. More heterogeneous in-party assessments imply lower affective polarization, as partisans are less unified in their feelings toward the parties.

Cross-National Survey Evidence

The theory I outline above generates several testable implications. Before diving into more complex analyses, I offer initial tests of key predictions in cross-national survey data. I use modules one through five of the Comparative Study of Electoral Systems (CSES), which surveyed respondents in 56 countries over the period 1996–2021, providing up to 226 total country-years.

Figure 1 reports the difference between presidential and parliamentary systems in six variables derived from CSES data. I code country-years as “presidential” if the head of government is neither appointed by nor accountable to the legislature.⁷ All models use ordinary least squares (OLS) regression with heteroskedasticity-consistent standard errors. In addition to bivariate models, pre-

⁷See the Israeli case study below for more details on institutional coding criteria. Results, shown in Supplementary Information (SI) section S2, are robust to an alternate coding scheme that requires country-years to satisfy only one of these criteria to be considered “presidential” (Samuels and Shugart 2010).

sented in black, I also adjust for the level of electoral democracy (Coppedge et al. 2020), logged GPD per capita (*World Development Indicators* 2021), income inequality as measured by the Gini coefficient (Solt 2020), and the effective number of legislative parties (Bormann and Golder 2022). Covariate-adjusted estimates are presented in gray. All variables are standardized to facilitate comparison.

My overarching prediction is that affective polarization should be lower in presidential democracies than in parliamentary ones. Accordingly, two aspects of citizens' party affect could differ (Mehlhaff 2024). First, there could be a narrower gap between how they feel about different parties. Second, partisans could display a wider range of feelings about parties, reflecting the wider range of perceptions they hold about party images. My theory suggests that effects of presidentialism primarily operate through perceptions of citizens' own party, since that is the set of elites to which they look for political cues. Thus, I expect citizens' feelings toward their own party to be less warm and more varied in presidential systems. I remain agnostic as to the effect among out-parties, since citizens pay less attention to messaging from parties with which they do not identify.

To test both conjectures about party affect, I examine respondents' assessments of how warmly they feel toward each party. I calculate the level of affect respondents feel toward their own party and toward the largest out-party in each election cycle.⁸ I also calculate the variance in respondents' affective attachments to each of these parties to get a sense of how unified partisans are in their affective evaluations.

Figure 1, plots A and B show the relationship between presidentialism and levels of party affect toward in- and out-parties, respectively. As expected, presidential systems experience cooler in-party affect, by more than half a standard deviation. By contrast, there is virtually no difference in

⁸I determine party size using the number of legislative seats won in that election. I limit the out-party analysis in this way to avoid estimates being inflated by smaller parties about which respondents may know relatively little.

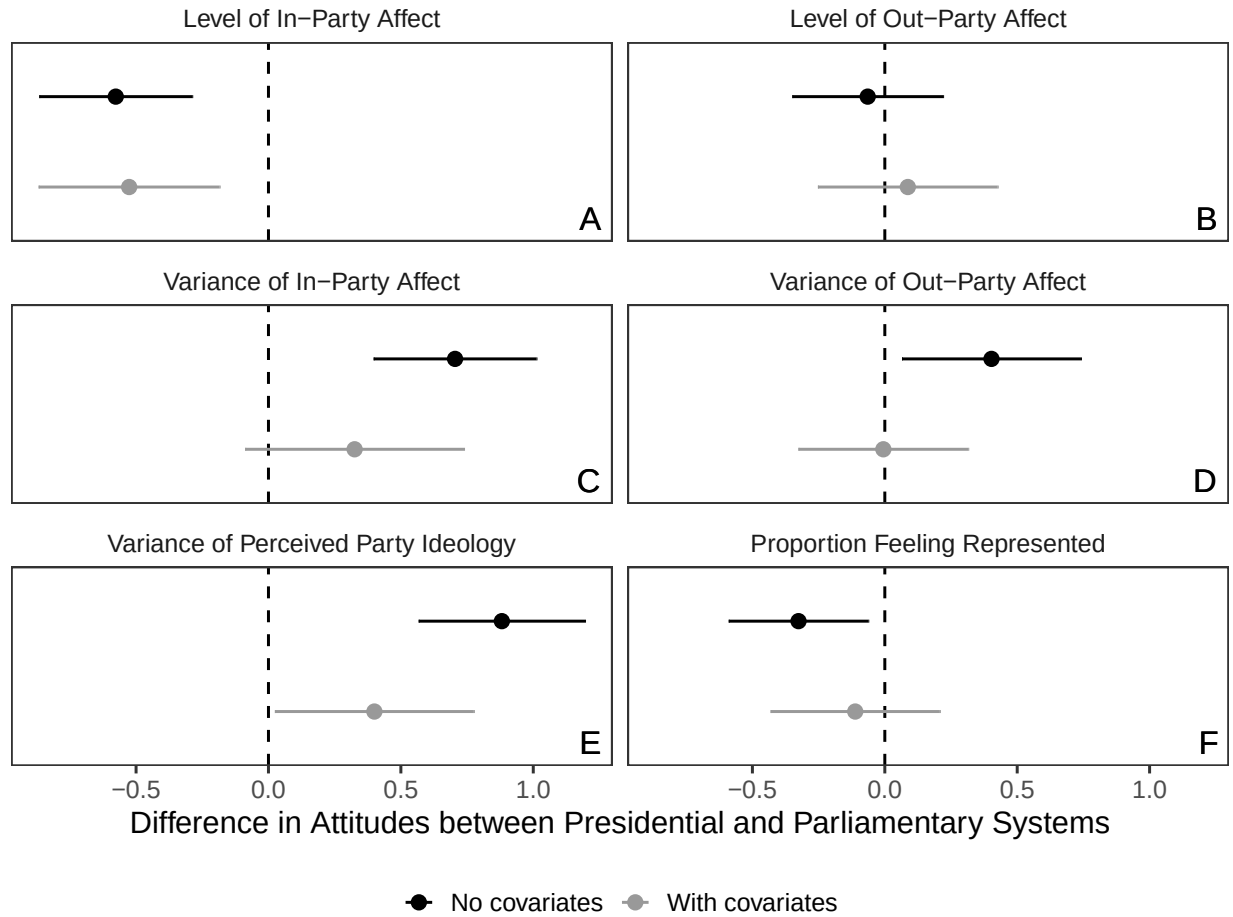


Figure 1: Cross-National Survey Evidence of Institutional Differences. Error bars give 95% confidence intervals. All models use OLS with heteroskedasticity-consistent standard errors. Full model results in SI section S2.

out-party affect across institutional types.⁹ In plots C and D, I turn to the variance in affect toward in- and out-parties. The variance of in-party affect is about three-quarters of a standard deviation higher in presidential systems, indicating that partisans are less unified in their feelings toward their party. The point estimate is not statistically significant when controlling for covariates, though it remains in the expected direction. The variance of out-party affect displays a similar pattern, but the effect magnitude is smaller in the bivariate model and almost exactly zero when adjusting

⁹In addition to full model results, I show in Supplementary Information (SI) section S2 that these in- and out-party effects combine to produce a narrower affective gap between parties in presidential systems.

for covariates. Overall, system-level differences in both inter-party heterogeneity and intra-party homogeneity appear to be driven by in-party evaluations more than out-party ones.

My expectations regarding party affect are largely driven by the assertion that, under presidentialism, elites project more varied programmatic signals and blur their party brand. If citizens pick up on these signals, I would also expect greater variation in how they evaluate parties' policy stances. The CSES asked respondents to place each party on the overall left-right scale. I calculate the average variance in each party's left-right placements to capture the clarity with which respondents perceive parties' positions. Figure 1, plot E displays the results. Voters' perceptions of parties' brands vary to a much greater degree under presidentialism, suggesting they see parties as projecting a less clear, less coherent ideological identity. This estimate attenuates slightly when adding covariates, but it remains positive and statistically significant.

Finally, unfocused party brands may even contribute to citizens decoupling from parties entirely. Accordingly, I calculate the proportion of respondents who report feeling that their views are well-represented by any party. Figure 1, plot F shows that presidential systems have fewer voters who feel represented by a party. The standardized effect is equivalent to a decrease of 9.3 percentage points and is directionally consistent but attenuated in a model with covariates.¹⁰

These cross-national data provide suggestive evidence of presidentialism's impact on citizens' perceptions of parties and, consequently, on affective polarization. However, they make it difficult to draw any conclusions beyond mere correlation. Executive institutions are not uniformly distributed; Latin America is "the continent of presidentialism" (Linz and Valenzuela 1994, p. x) while parliamentary systems are concentrated in Western Europe and former British colonies. As partially demonstrated by the models including covariates, it is difficult to separate the effects of institutions from the effects of other covariates, such as economic development (Horowitz 1990; Mainwaring and Shugart 1997). For this reason, Shugart and Mainwaring (1997) call on re-

¹⁰Results are similar when using the proportion of respondents expressing party identification, shown in SI section S2.

searchers to move past correlational evidence of institutional effects and examine more appropriate counterfactuals.

Quasi-Experimental Context: Institutional Reform in Israel

To infer a causal relationship between presidentialism and affective polarization, I need to know how polarized a presidential democracy would be *if it were parliamentary*. This is a difficult quantity to estimate, since it is impossible for a country to be both presidential and parliamentary at the same time. The next best option is to observe how a single country changes as it transitions from one institutional structure to the other (e.g. Abadie et al. 2015; Górecki and Pierzgałski 2023; Roesel 2017). To that end, I use Israel’s brief experience with a directly elected chief executive to identify a causal effect of presidentialism on affective polarization, in addition to several intermediate outcomes.

Israel’s shift from fused to separate origin (and, to a limited degree, separate survival) was the outcome of long-simmering concerns over governability, accountability, and the distribution of bargaining power in a fragmented proportional representation (PR) system, culminating in a crisis of confidence in 1990 (Brichta 1998; Diskin and Diskin 1995). Throughout the 1970s and 1980s, political elites, scholars, and advocates debated institutional reforms to stabilize coalitions and clarify responsibility to voters. They included proposals to raise the electoral threshold, implement a mixed-member proportional system, or adjust rules related to confidence and government dissolution (Doron and Kay 1995; Harris and Doron 1999; Hazan 1996).

These proposals repeatedly failed. Small parties vetoed change over fears they would lose political leverage, major parties distrusted each other and worried they would be systematically disadvantaged, and backbenchers were reluctant to put their reelection chances in jeopardy (Diskin and Diskin 1995; Doron and Kay 1995; Rahat 2001). Instead of continuing to press for legislative reforms that concentrated losses on identifiable actors, advocates pared down previous proposals until the only major element remaining was direct election of the prime minister. “Basic Law:

The Government (1992)” grafted a directly elected executive onto a PR system that was otherwise untouched (Brichta 1998; Hazan 1996; Rahat 2008a).¹¹ This move promised a clearer mandate for the head of government, left the electoral system intact, and could be passed with a simple majority vote (Harris and Doron 1999; Hazan 1996; Rahat 2001).¹²

Contrary to reformers’ hopes, the post-reform period saw further party system fragmentation as voters backed major-party prime ministerial candidates while allocating their legislative votes to niche or religious lists (Hazan and Rahat 2000; Peretz and Doron 2000). The two large parties lost even more bargaining power and pre-electoral alliances did not translate into durable legislative coalitions (Harris and Doron 1999; Hazan 2001). Instead, cabinet formation continued to rely on cross-party bargaining in an increasingly fractured Knesset (Arian and Shamir 1999; Bueno de Mesquita 2000). Israel returned to standard parliamentarism in 2001, less than a decade later (Ottolenghi 2001; Rahat 2006).

Nevertheless, Israel’s brief experience with direct executive elections provides a valuable opportunity to identify a causal effect of institutional change. Without making any other changes, the institutional reform introduced *de jure* separate origin. It also had the unintended consequence of introducing *de facto* separate survival. The Knesset technically retained the power to dismiss the cabinet, and the prime minister could likewise choose to dissolve the Knesset. However, either action would trigger new elections for *both* prime minister and Knesset.¹³ This mutually assured destruction made it much less likely that either branch would use their dissolution power (Diskin

¹¹The resulting system most resembled a presidential-parliamentary system (Hazan 1996; Shugart and Carey 1992). Some parties also implemented primaries to select their prime ministerial candidate, but they were not required to do so and most parties quickly abandoned those efforts (Doron and Kay 1995; Rahat 2008b).

¹²The head of state—primarily a ceremonial figurehead—continued to be appointed by the Knesset.

¹³The Knesset could avoid such a fate by marshaling a supermajority on the vote of no confidence, but this was a tall order in such a fragmented legislature.

1999; Sartori 1994). Further, prime ministers were effectively unaccountable to their own party. Stripped of the power to appoint a co-partisan as they could in a parliamentary system, parties controlling the executive had no incentive to remove the prime minister. Doing so would only trigger a new election, with no guarantee they would retain the office (Samuels and Shugart 2010).

Moreover, although the reform is clearly not exogenous to political considerations (e.g. Hermann 1995), it was the product of elite bargaining under uncertainty and not a response to mass attitudinal change (Doron and Kay 1995; Rahat 2001). It isolated a core institutional feature while minimizing changes to the rules that structure other arenas of political competition. Lijphart (2012) cites these institutional particularities in classifying Israel as a presidential system during this period. Comparing Israel's experience before and after the reform to those countries which maintained either separate origin or survival throughout the same time period allows me to identify the effect of executive institutions on key variables of interest.¹⁴

Assessing Impact on Affective Polarization

The overarching hypothesis structuring my argument is that presidential institutions should depress affective polarization levels. I begin by testing this conjecture directly, exploiting Israel's switch to a directly elected head of government in the 1990s. Results from synthetic control models indicate Israel's institutional reform led to a decrease in affective polarization, relative to what it would have otherwise experienced.

Data and Methods

Identifying the causal effect of institutional reform requires data with high temporal frequency and broad geographic coverage, preferably in the form of country-level *panels* rather than repeated cross-sections. Most existing datasets tracking affective polarization cross-nationally do not satisfy these requirements. Scholars relying on the CSES can bring to bear, at most, six observations per

¹⁴Samuels (2002) and Samuels and Shugart (2010) use the Israeli case for similar purposes.

country (Gidron et al. 2020; Reiljan et al. 2024; Wagner 2021). Stitching together multiple sources to increase the number of country-years introduces harmonization challenges (Boxell et al. 2024; Garzia et al. 2023): item wording and response scales differ across surveys, identical questions can be interpreted differently across settings (Stegmueller 2011), and sampling and fieldwork protocols vary across survey programs. Even after adjusting for these differences, the time series remain sparse, making them ill-suited to detect shifts in country-level trajectories at specific points in time.

I therefore use affective polarization estimates from the Polarization in Comparative Attitudes Project (PolarCAP; Mehlhaff 2025). PolarCAP pools about 3.5 million respondents across 35 survey programs and applies latent variable models to correct for forms of non-stochastic measurement variation (see also Claassen 2019). The models also smooth over time to produce estimates for every country-year, including years without raw survey observations. I analyze annual affective polarization estimates for 49 countries from 1975—the first year with available data—through 2001, when Israel returned to parliamentarism. Relative to other data sources, these estimates offer three important advantages: they align more closely with the concept of polarization by capturing both intergroup heterogeneity and intragroup homogeneity (Esteban and Ray 1994; Fortunato and Stevenson 2021; Mehlhaff 2024), their broad spatial and temporal coverage supports more generalizable inference, and the panel structure enables time-series causal tests described below.

I also need to group countries according to which type of executive institution they employ. I code countries as “presidential” if the head of government satisfies two criteria: First, they are either directly elected, or they are appointed by a head of state who is not chosen by the legislature. Second, they do not rely on the legislature for confidence. If a head of government does not enjoy both separate origin and separate survival from the legislature, I do not consider their system presidential.¹⁵ As a result, the control group includes a variety of semi-presidential systems that

¹⁵Under Israel’s reform, fused survival was a technicality; in practice, it was difficult for the Knesset to credibly threaten the prime minister with dismissal.

combine, for instance, separate origin with fused survival. For clarity of exposition, I nevertheless refer to these systems as “parliamentary.”¹⁶

Three additional notes on this coding scheme merit mention. First, I focus on the head of government instead of each country’s figurehead leader (such as the president in France) because it offers a cleaner comparison to the Israeli case, which altered selection rules for its head of government while leaving its head of state unaffected. Second, requiring both separate origin and survival to classify a system as “presidential” likely provides a hard test of the theory; those systems may experience some effect of presidentialism, but it should be of lesser magnitude than systems with both features. Finally, to identify the causal effect of the institutional change, I need to assume political actors did not begin adjusting their behavior—such as party strategy and rhetoric—before the change took place. It seems likely that parties changed their strategy soon after the reform passed as they adapted to the new method of executive selection. I therefore designate 1992 as the first year in which Israel experienced treatment, even though the reformed institutions were not used in practice until subsequent elections.

Gaining causal purchase on this test requires me to compare the actual level of affective polarization observed in Israel to the level we *would have observed* if the reform had never been enacted. Synthetic control methods offer a powerful framework for estimating this counterfactual quantity when there is only one treated unit, as is the case here (Abadie 2021; Abadie et al. 2010). The first step in the generalized synthetic control method focuses on the pre-treatment period, using an interactive fixed effects model to learn patterns in control units that accurately predict the treated unit’s outcomes *before* it undergoes treatment (Xu 2017).¹⁷ I adjust for the same covariates as in

¹⁶I use the same coding scheme in the cross-national analysis above. SI section S1 shows institutional coding for each country-year, discusses edge cases, and validates the coding scheme against two publicly available datasets. I also show that comparing Israel only to pure parliamentary systems does not change the conclusions of any analysis (Samuels and Shugart 2010).

¹⁷In SI section S3.2, I show that results do not differ substantially by using a matrix completion estimator (Athey et al. 2021) or a generalized difference-in-differences model.

the cross-national analysis above. The model then applies the patterns learned from pre-treatment data to the post-treatment period, building a “synthetic” control for the treated unit. Finally, subtracting the synthetic (untreated) outcome from the observed (treated) outcome and averaging over the time periods under treatment provides the average treatment effect on the treated unit (ATT).¹⁸

A final consideration is how to perform statistical inference. With only one treated unit, I cannot calculate standard errors that rely on asymptotic assumptions, and even a nonparametric bootstrap will produce downward-biased standard errors (e.g. Alrababa’h et al. 2021). I therefore use two different methods to obtain uncertainty estimates. First, Xu (2017) provides a parametric bootstrap approach that resamples full time series of model residuals, thereby avoiding bias from serial correlation. Second, I conduct a permutation test in which I shuffle countries’ treatment statuses and re-estimate the model on each shuffled dataset (Abadie et al. 2010; Alrababa’h et al. 2021). This procedure produces a null distribution of treatment effects against which to test the effect estimated for Israel.

Results

Figure 2 visualizes the effect of switching to direct executive elections using two different plots. The top plot shows the level of affective polarization in Israel over time. The solid line provides the observed outcome throughout the full time series and the dashed line provides the estimated counterfactual—the level of affective polarization Israel would have been expected to experience if it never implemented the institutional reform. The difference between the solid and dashed black lines therefore denotes the treatment effect in each year.

The vertical line indicates the treatment cutoff. During years to the left of the vertical line, all units are coded as “parliamentary.” Counterfactuals track observed outcomes closely in this period, indicating the model is well-calibrated to patterns in the pre-treatment data that enable it to construct an accurate synthetic control in the post-treatment period. During years to the right of the vertical line, Israel is coded as having “presidential” institutions, while all other units remained

¹⁸For a more detailed explication, see SI section S3.1.

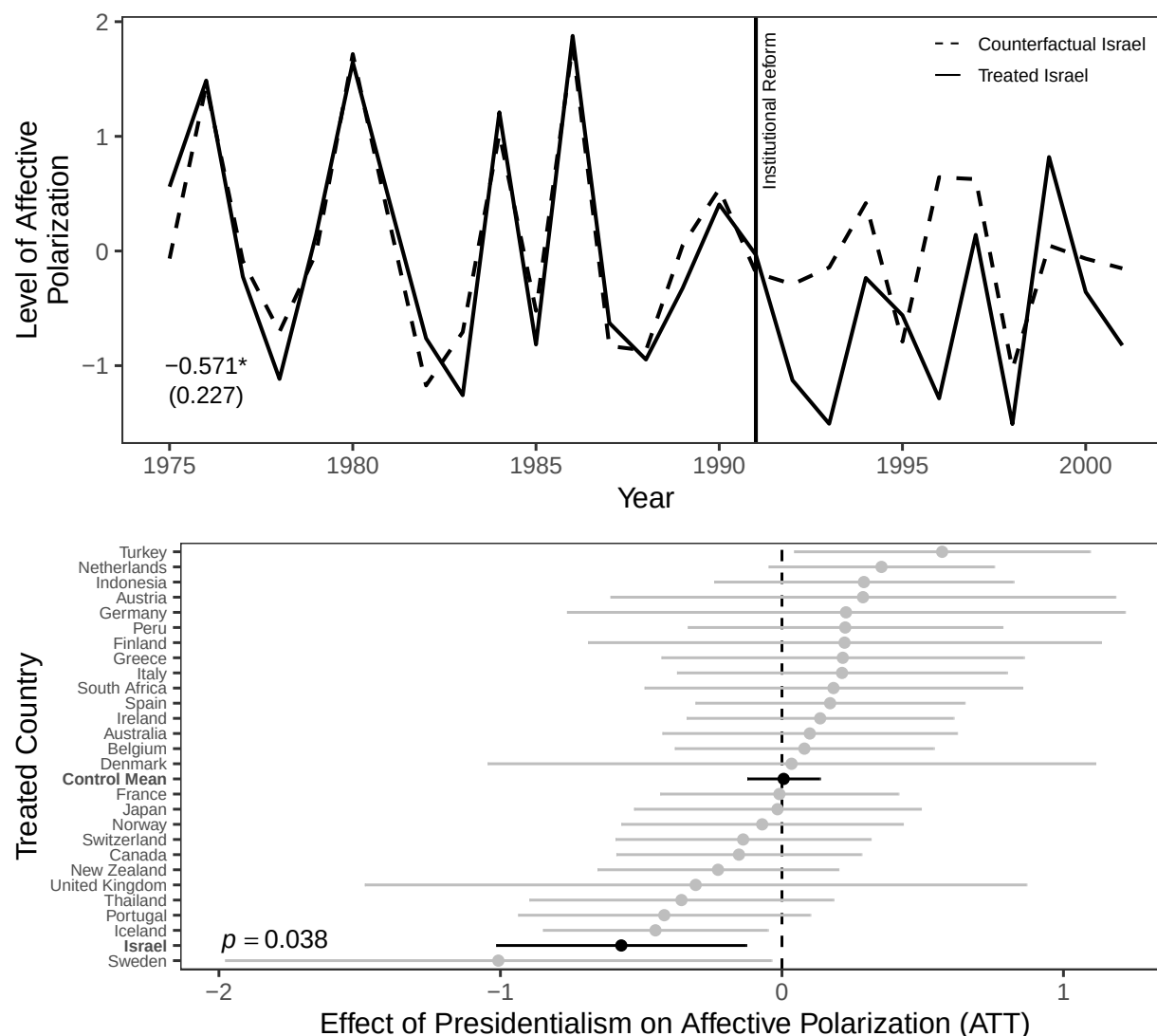


Figure 2: Comparison of Observed and Synthetic Affective Polarization Levels in Israel. Top plot: difference between solid and dashed black lines represents treatment effect; annotated numbers indicate ATT, parametrically bootstrapped standard error, and statistical significance ($*p < 0.05$); affective polarization is standardized. Bottom plot: ATT and 95% confidence intervals for each unit in permutation test; annotated number is p -value.

parliamentary. In this period, the level of observed polarization is consistently lower than the level Israel would have experienced had it continued down the path of parliamentarism.¹⁹ The overall

¹⁹1999 is an exception. This election featured sharp disagreements over the implementation of the Oslo Accords (Peretz and Doron 2000) and perceptions the country was “in a state of deep crisis” (Yanai 2002, p. 228).

ATT is -0.571 standard deviations, with a parametrically bootstrapped standard error of 0.227 ($p < 0.05$). To put this effect magnitude in context, the average level of affective polarization in South Africa—the most polarized country over the post-treatment period—was 0.709 standard deviations above the mean. The effect of implementing presidential institutions in Israel was thus akin to moving from among the most bitterly polarized countries to one that was only slightly above average.

The bottom plot displays the ATT in Israel against the ATTs estimated for all control units in the permutation test. The gray lines in the bottom plot thus represent the null distribution of ATTs I use to calculate the permutation-based p -value annotated in the bottom-left corner. This test enables me to assess statistical significance by reassigning the treatment to units that were not, in fact, treated and subsequently re-fitting the synthetic control model to the permuted data. Since none of the control units experienced changes in executive institutions over the time period analyzed, the treatment effect among these units should be zero on average. Indeed, the control units plotted in the bottom plot of Figure 2 are approximately symmetric around zero, and the null distribution of treatment effects generated by the permutation procedure has a mean of only 0.006 . Comparing the treatment effect in Israel to this null distribution indicates the effect of presidentialism on affective polarization in Israel is statistically significant at the $\alpha = 0.05$ level.²⁰

The overall pattern of results supports the central hypothesis that presidential institutions depress party-based affective polarization in the mass public. Israel’s experience with a directly elected executive in the 1990s led to lower affective polarization levels than would be expected in the absence of institutional reform. Placebo tests in SI section S3.3 suggest this result is likely not driven by pre-treatment trends, mechanical features of the synthetic control model, or confounding from contemporaneous political events such as the Oslo Accords, assassination of Prime Minister Yitzhak Rabin, or mass immigration of ethnic Jews following the collapse of the Soviet Union. SI

²⁰The permutation test contains fewer countries than the main analysis, as some control units lack sufficient pre-treatment data for permutation. With relatively few control units, the permutation p -value may be conservative.

section S3.4 shows that incorporating measurement uncertainty into the synthetic control models does not alter results. The following two sections probe possible mechanisms undergirding this overall effect.

Muddled Party Brands, Atrophied Party Organizations

My theory linking presidentialism to lower affective polarization relies on parties adapting their behavior to different executive institutions. In particular, separate origin should lead parties to have broader, less coherent brands and weaker organizations (Doyle and Power 2020; Mainwaring and Scully 1995; Samuels and Shugart 2010). Party identities should be less strongly rooted when parties present unclear programmatic appeals and rely on personalist rather than party-based appeals, resulting in lower affective polarization. I previously presented cross-sectional evidence for the variation in voters' party evaluations and causal evidence for the overall negative effect of presidentialism on affective polarization. Here, I again use the Israeli case to show presidentialism leads to less coherent party brands and diminished organizational vitality.

Data and Methods

I take two sets of variables from the Varieties of Party Identity and Organization (V-Party) project (Düpont et al. 2022). A close relative to the Varieties of Democracy project (V-Dem; Coppedge et al. 2020), V-Party solicits expert annotations of party characteristics over a long historical period and aggregates those individual coder assessments using a Bayesian latent variable model.

The first set of variables speaks to the clarity of parties' policy proposals. I examine four issues that have long been salient in Israeli politics: economic left-right placement, immigration policies, views toward minority rights (including ethnic, religious, and sexual minorities), and the degree to which party priorities were driven by religious principles. However, I am not interested in *where* the parties positioned themselves on each dimension. Rather, I need to measure *clarity* with which they did so. Fortunately, V-Party includes not only point estimates for each party's placement,

but also the variance surrounding those estimates. In effect, this variance represents the degree of uncertainty about where each party stood on each issue, with much of that uncertainty coming from variation in individual coder assessments. If direct executive elections led party positions to become less clear, I would expect the variance surrounding estimates of their policy positions to increase. To aggregate these variance estimates to the country-year level, I average over all parties evaluated in each country-year.

The second set captures party organization and behavior. First, I examine the extent to which parties engage in negative campaigning against their opponents; if cross-party attacks decrease, that would help explain why affective polarization declines under presidentialism. Another intermediate outcome I posited above was an increase in personalist voting, so I examine the degree to which parties revolve around individual leaders. Finally, I operationalize the health of party organizations by examining the extent to which each party supports a permanent cadre of party activists in local communities and how widespread party offices are in the country's municipalities. If direct elections lead parties to shift control to presidential campaigns and away from more institutionalized forms of party organization, I would expect these measures of organizational strength to decline and the degree to which party appeals are centered on individual leaders to increase. As with the first set of variables, I aggregate party-level scores to the country-year level by averaging over all parties.

To estimate the causal effect of Israel's institutional reform on these party-level outcomes, I use the same generalized synthetic control approach as in the previous section, controlling for the same set of covariates. This allows me to compare observed post-reform trends in party positioning uncertainty and party behavior to a counterfactual in which Israel retained its parliamentary institutions. Standard errors are again obtained via parametric bootstrap.

Results

Figure 3 plots generalized synthetic control results for each set of variables. As in Figure 2, the solid lines show the observed outcomes in Israel, and the dashed lines denote the counterfactual

Israel. ATT estimates are printed on each facet, along with the parametrically bootstrapped standard error and an indication of whether the estimate is statistically significant ($*p < 0.05$).²¹ All variables are standardized to facilitate comparison.

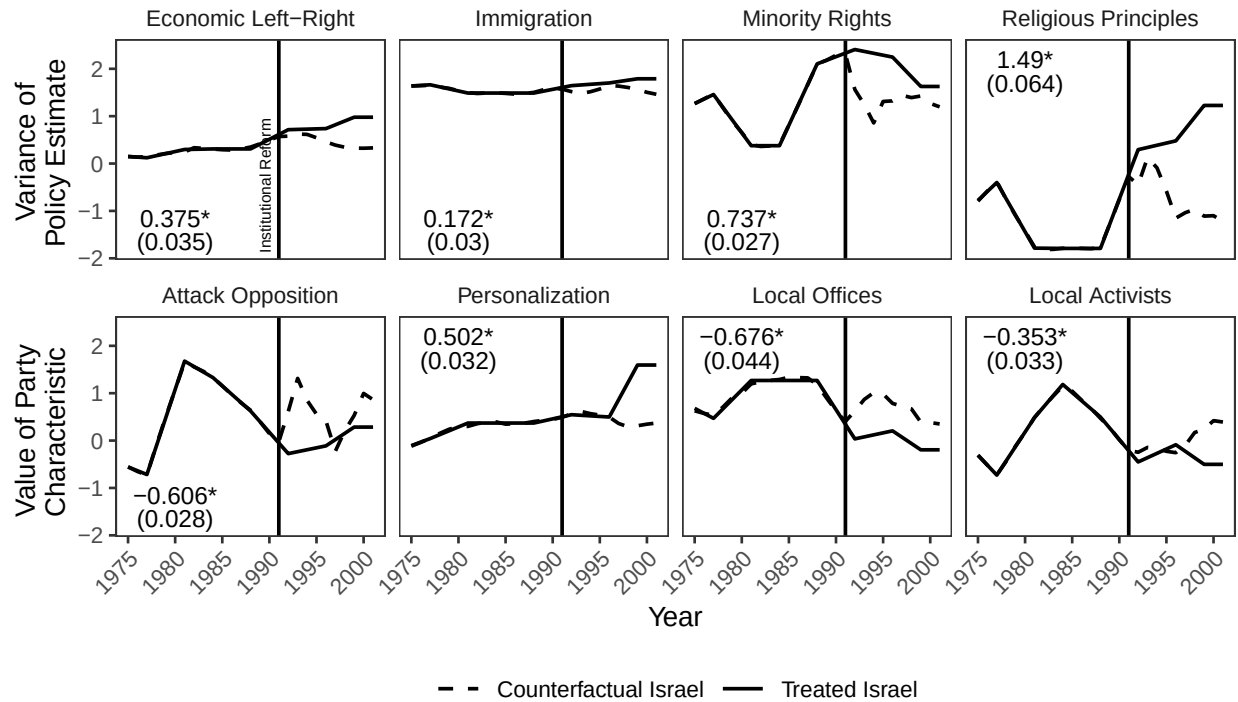


Figure 3: Effect of Institutional Reform on Party Characteristics and Uncertainty of Party Positioning. Difference between solid and dashed black lines represents treatment effect. Annotated numbers indicate ATT, parametrically bootstrapped standard error, and statistical significance ($*p < 0.05$). Variables standardized for comparison.

I focus first on the variables capturing the degree of uncertainty surrounding parties' issue positions, plotted in the top row of Figure 3. The differences between the solid and dashed black lines in the post-reform period represent the causal effect of the reform on the clarity of issue positions. All four models exhibit positive, statistically significant treatment effects. Effects for economic and immigration policies are modest, but estimates for support of minority rights and incorporation of religious principles are more drastic. In both of the latter, the degree of uncertainty surrounding party positions increased prior to treatment onset. Each model predicted reversions to

²¹Full tabular results and permutation tests are presented in SI section S4.

prior uncertainty levels, but they instead remained high and even continued to increase in the case of religious principles. These results suggest parties responded to the implementation of direct executive elections by projecting less coherent policy, which manifested in greater uncertainty surrounding each party's programmatic identity.

I next turn to party organization and behavior, plotted in the bottom row of Figure 3. The bottom-left facet shows the reform decreased parties' propensity to engage in negative campaigning or demonize their opponents. This positions opposition attacks as another possible mechanism linking direct elections to lower affective polarization. Also as predicted, the second facet shows Israeli parties experienced a rapid increase in personalization, marking a significant change from the estimated counterfactual. Finally, the two facets on the bottom-right identify negative, statistically significant effects on party organization. Israeli parties maintained weaker local networks and fewer local offices than they would have been expected to in the absence of the institutional reform.

Less Affectively Charged Messaging

In previous analyses, I showed that direct executive elections blur parties' brands and weaken their organizations, and that citizens adjust their attitudes in response to these changes. One way the party-level effects could trickle down to mass attitudes is through changes to political messaging conveyed through news media. In this final empirical analysis, I show the tone of political content available to Israeli citizens in the news became more neutral during the period of direct elections. In combination with less negative campaigning by parties, less caustic coverage of party politics could help explain declines in affective polarization.

Data and Methods

News media acts as a prism for political messaging, repackaging party rhetoric for mass consumption. In their effort to grow and maintain their audience, media organizations are often incentivized

to stoke political tension in a way that appeals to partisans and delegitimizes alternate information sources (Benkler et al. 2018; Berry and Sobieraj 2014). Media can thus reflect—if not contribute to—polarization processes occurring in both parties and the mass public (Mutz 2015; Pierson and Schickler 2020). If parties alter their behavior in response to institutional change, it may also be reflected in the tone of news coverage.

To test this conjecture, I construct a corpus of newspaper headlines published in *The Jerusalem Post* from 1975 to 2001. Headlines represent a reasonable proxy for the political messaging to which citizens are exposed. They are pithy summaries of an article’s content, designed to grab readers’ attention, and more likely to be read in their entirety compared to the body of the article. I collect headlines from all articles mentioning at least one of three topics: political parties, party leaders, or the Knesset.²² Articles could touch on political subjects without mentioning one of these topics, but my objective is to examine the headlines most likely to reflect party rhetoric and political messaging informing citizens’ attitudes toward parties.

To ensure I am not merely capturing a national mood or general trends in media coverage, I also analyze two placebo outcomes: headlines focused on business and the economy and on culture and entertainment. These placebos represent outcomes that are closely tied to current events and often discussed by parties, but do not implicate politics directly. If the institutional reform defused party-based rhetoric, I would expect it to change the trajectory of political headlines but not of headlines related to other topics. These searches yield a total of 302,369 headlines—111,785 mentioning politics, 149,493 on economics, and 76,981 on culture.

I focus on *The Jerusalem Post* for two reasons. First, the *Post* has long been a major news source with significant national and global relevance (Frenkel 1994; Zvielli 1992). As the largest English-language newspaper in Israel, it played a major role in communicating Israeli politics to audiences both at home and abroad—including the Jewish diaspora (Cohen 2007; Dridi 2020). Second, the *Post* is one of few Israeli newspapers with fully digitized, publicly available archives covering the entire historical period of interest, and certainly the most prominent of those newspapers. Because

²²Search parameters are provided in SI section S5.1.

it has been published in English since its founding, I can use sentiment analysis tools developed for English-language text and avoid semantic distortions that could be introduced through translation (Lucas et al. 2015).

I calculate four measures for each headline. First, subjectivity captures the degree to which a headline contains opinions or emotion instead of factual, neutral language (Liu 2010). It is thus conceptually distinct from but closely related to sentiment, and gives a sense of the degree to which headlines slant their coverage or engage in editorializing. If direct executive elections decrease affective polarization, I would also expect to see decreasing subjectivity in news coverage.

The next three measures break the sentiment of a headline into positive, negative, and neutral components. Affective polarization invokes both positive and negative feelings; lower affective polarization should be associated with less negative rhetoric meant to tear down other parties, but also less positive rhetoric meant to build up one's own. Following the institutional reform, I expect negative and positive sentiment to both decrease, while neutral sentiment should increase. I calculate sentiment using the Valence-Aware Dictionary for sEntiment Reasoning (VADER), an open-source, dictionary-based model designed for use on short texts like news headlines (Bestvater and Monroe 2023; Hutto and Gilbert 2014).

Because I only have observations from one newspaper in one country, a synthetic control approach is not feasible. Instead, I use interrupted time series models to estimate the effect of the institutional reform on each measure of headline sentiment. Interrupted time series estimate both immediate and sustained effects of a discrete intervention when that intervention affects the entire population at the same time (Anderton and Carter 2001; Cross and Bølstad 2015).²³ I focus on the sustained change; I expect the effect on media content to accumulate as parties adjust their behavior and the media respond in turn.

One factor that could complicate inference is the *Post*'s changing editorial status. During the second half of the twentieth century, the *Post* was ideologically left-of-center and at least tacitly supported the Labor Party. In 1989, three years before the institutional reform, a new ownership

²³See SI section S5.2 for a detailed model explication.

and editorial group shifted the paper back toward mainstream Zionism (Zvielli 1992). It continued to track to the political right until another ownership change in 2004—outside the temporal scope of my analysis. Therefore, if patterns in the newspaper’s headline sentiment change after the institutional reform, it may be difficult to know whether that is due to changes in party behavior and electoral incentives brought on by the reform, or whether it is due to changing editorial preferences.

However, the effects one would expect from a newspaper veering rightward are the opposite of what I theoretically expect as a result of institutional change. To the extent the *Post*’s new ideological lean affected its printed content, I would expect it to *increase* subjectivity, negative sentiment, and positive sentiment, and to *decrease* neutral sentiment. The *Post*’s editorial change may therefore offer a hard test of the theory by driving effect estimates toward zero. The placebo outcomes can help further assess any overarching changes to editorial strategy. Regardless, there is reasonable doubt surrounding the assumptions required for causal inference in this analysis, so I interpret the results as purely correlational.

Results

If institutional reform had a sustained effect on the tone of political messaging conveyed in *The Jerusalem Post*, trend lines of sentiment over time should have different slopes before and after the reform, reflecting changes in party rhetoric in response to new electoral incentives. Figure 4 plots the four measures of sentiment over time, broken down across panels. Black lines represent trends in sentiment for political headlines, while gray lines represent trends for the placebo headlines. All measures are standardized to facilitate comparison across panels, and shaded error bands give 95% confidence intervals.

When it comes to political headlines, all four varieties of sentiment exhibit clear changes in trend following the reform. Subjectivity, shown in the top-left plot of Figure 4, slowly increased from 1975 until the reform, after which headlines began to rapidly employ more objective, factual language. Positive sentiment, shown in the bottom-right plot, displays similar patterns. Notably, there is little to no change in sentiment around the treatment cutoff, indicating the effect on media

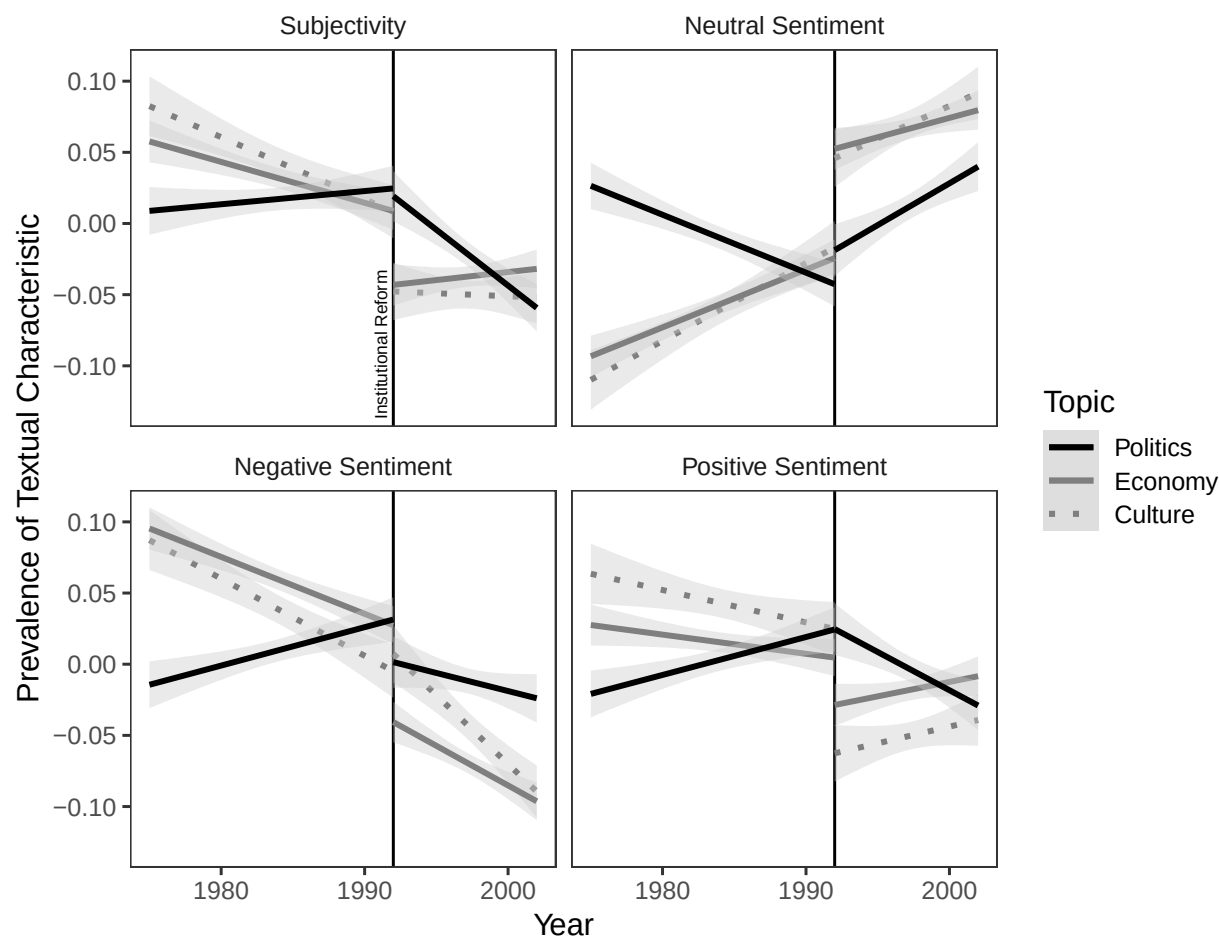


Figure 4: Trends in Newspaper Headline Sentiment Before and After Reform. Variables standardized for comparison. Error bands give 95% confidence intervals. See SI section S5.3 for tabular results.

tone took time to develop. Neutral and negative sentiment, in the upper-right and bottom-left plots, respectively, do show some evidence of immediate change, but the sustained changes are more pronounced. Neutral sentiment dramatically increased after the reform and negative sentiment decreased, or at least stopped its upward climb. All estimates are statistically significant at the $\alpha = 0.05$ level after adjusting standard errors for heteroskedasticity and autocorrelation (Newey and West 1987).²⁴

The placebo outcomes evince different patterns. Subjectivity and positive sentiment were both decreasing prior to the reform and are flat or slightly increasing afterward—the opposite of the

²⁴See SI section S5.3 for tabular results.

trends theoretically predicted and observed in political headlines. Neutral and negative sentiment did increase and decrease after the reform, respectively, but these were merely continuations of the trends started more than a decade earlier. Collectively, these analyses uncover a shift in media coverage to transmit less affectively charged political messaging. Such changes did not reflect a more general change in media strategy but were instead limited to political headlines, suggesting party messaging may be one mechanism through which presidential institutions can defuse affective polarization in the mass public.

Discussion

My core thesis is that executive institutions shape mass attitudes by altering the ways in which parties present themselves to voters. Because parties in presidential systems must appeal to different constituencies in executive and legislative elections, they tend to develop broader, less coherent brands and weaker party organizations. As a result, it is more difficult for voters to ascertain where each party stands, and intra-party variation in positioning leads parties' adherents in the mass public to feel less firmly rooted in their political identity. Because parties are organizationally weaker, it is more difficult for them to mount public messaging campaigns to attack opposition parties.

The upshot of all these effects is that presidentialism exerts downward pressure on party-based affective polarization in the mass public. This conclusion merits some qualification. First, I do not mean to imply presidential systems cannot be polarized; some countries with presidents have quite combative politics indeed. Rather, I argue that presidential systems are likely to be less polarized than they would be if they were instead parliamentary. Second, I make no claim about whether the party system itself becomes more or less polarized under presidentialism. My contention is that parties become less coherent and the *electorate* is less polarized as a result.

Most of the evidence I present relies on the identification strategy provided by the 1992 institutional reform in Israel. To some extent, I am thus generalizing from this single case of direct executive elections to presidential systems more broadly. On one hand, results could be vulnerable

to idiosyncrasies of the Israeli case. Maybe the particular combination of executive and legislative institutions in Israel helps drive the effect (Shugart and Carey 1992). Or perhaps imposing presidentialism on a political system already fraught with particularism helped facilitate national goods provision, removing incentives for party conflict (Shugart 1999). On the other hand, the types of mechanisms I examine tend to differ more *across* system types than *within* them (Samuels and Shugart 2010), suggesting a more limited explanatory role for the particularities of the Israeli case. That insight, combined with the cross-national evidence I present, suggests results could be robust to a wide range of conditioning factors.

This work contributes a new perspective to debates on presidential democracy and underscores the conditioning impacts of institutional configurations. Great effort has been dedicated to understanding the dangers polarization poses to democratic stability (e.g. McCoy et al. 2018). However, scholars have given less thought to how democratic institutions themselves may shape polarization. If one takes at face value the claim that presidentialism threatens democracy, then the fact that presidentialism also depresses affective polarization implies that polarization may not carry the negative causal consequences for democracy that scholars frequently assume.

Nevertheless, the party-weakening effects of presidentialism could push the pendulum too far in the opposite direction. Decades before the third wave of democratization, Schattschneider (1942, p. 1) famously asserted that “political parties created democracy and modern democracy is unthinkable save in terms of the parties.” If presidentialism weakens party attachments, it could still have corrosive effects on democracy. Scholars of Latin America point out how uprooted parties, poor representation, and ideological convergence in party systems contribute to poor democratic quality (Mainwaring and Scully 1995; Morgan 2011). But even in this version of events, democratic erosion would not be due to polarization, but to the institutional configuration itself.

There is yet another, even less sanguine, interpretation of this evidence. Presidential systems are more likely to produce weak, personalist parties, leading voters to identify with individual political elites rather than a larger party label—they support *Chavismo* in Venezuela or *Peronismo* in Argentina. What is important to these voters is not that their preferred *party* remains in power

but that their preferred *leader* does. Or, if they dislike the figurehead of these movements, they think it critical to depose them. The outcome remains the same—citizens are less tightly attached to their parties and party-based affective polarization may therefore be lower—but the mechanism differs from the theoretical story I propose. If strong personalism links presidentialism to affective polarization, the consequences for democracy could still be severe.

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